

Introduction

Flags are part of everyday life. They are used by countries, provinces, cities, international bodies, organizations, and companies.

EARLY FLAGS

The earliest known flags were used in China, to indicate different parts of the army. In Europe flags began with the Roman vexillum, a square flag used by Roman cavalry, from which the term “vexillology”—the study of flags—originated. In the Middle Ages, heraldry became important as a means of identifying kings and lords. The distinctive coats of arms which developed were used as flags, and some still exist today.

FLAGS FOR IDENTIFICATION

The most significant development of flags was for use at sea. Ships flew flags for identification at a distance, and many of the rules of flag-use developed at sea. Some well-known flags were designed specifically for naval use, including the Dutch and Spanish flags (*see pages 121 & 136*) and the International code flags (*see page 238*), which were used by ships to communicate with each other.

POLITICAL FLAGS

With the growth of independent nation states, flags have become

more important in politics. Many newly-independent states choose flags based on those of the political parties which secured independence. Revolutionary movements usually have their own flags, and private and professional organizations are increasingly adopting flags.

This book deals with national, international and subnational flags, and national coats of arms, and is arranged continent by continent. Among national flags are the state ensign and flag, for government use only on sea and land; the civil ensign and flag, for private and commercial use; and the naval ensign, flown by warships. Subnational flags may be of states (USA), provinces (Canada), cantons (Switzerland), overseas territories, or other such areas.

KEY FLAGS IN WORLD HISTORY

Throughout history certain flags have become the inspiration of others, starting with the Stars and Stripes in 1777 (*see pages 11–12*) ; which has inspired more flags than any other. The same degree of influence has been exercised by the French Tricolore from 1794, (*see page 131*), the Dutch Tricolor (*see page 121*) and its major derivative the Russian Tricolor (*see page 168*) which gave rise to most of the flags of eastern Europe.